“Because church people hurt me, God must be just like them.”

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Where it often comes from

When those who speak for God use that voice to control, shame, or harm, it is hard to separate them from God. A pastor’s betrayal, a youth leader’s abuse of trust, or a church’s harsh rejection can leave a child or adult convinced that God shares their coldness or cruelty.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture describes God’s own character: “The LORD, the LORD God, is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion and faithfulness.” “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit.” Of His servant it says, “A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish.” The writer of Hebrews says that Jesus, our high priest, sympathizes with our weaknesses. God never promised that every person speaking in His name reflects Him. The measure of God is Jesus, who was gentle with the wounded and angry only at those who burdened them.

> *“The LORD is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion”* (Psalm 103:8).

Also see

> “Then the LORD passed in front of Moses and called out: ‘The LORD, the LORD God, is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion and faithfulness.’” (Exodus 34:6).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish; He will faithfully bring forth justice” (Isaiah 42:3).

> “For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who was tempted in every way that we are, yet was without sin” (Hebrews 4:15).

Common self-statements

- If that is what Christians are like, I want nothing to do with God.
- God let them do it, so He must be like them.
- They spoke for God, so God must agree with them.
- I cannot trust God after that.
- All religion is just control.
- God is as harsh as they were.

Common logical errors

- Overgeneralizing: Letting a few people stand for God and all believers.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling betrayed and concluding God is the same.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing the church and God are either both good or both bad.
- Guilt by association: Judging God by those who claimed to represent Him.

Challenging questions

- What exactly was done to me, and who did it?
- Did those people actually reflect God's character as Scripture describes it?
- How does Jesus treat people who are hurt by religious leaders?
- Is it fair to judge God by those who misrepresented Him?
- What do I want God to be like?
- What would it look like to read the Gospels to see Jesus for myself?

Truth summary

> People who hurt me in God's name misrepresented Him. God is compassionate, gracious, and near to the brokenhearted. I can grieve what was done and take my time getting to know the real God through Jesus.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Church
- Hypocritical
- God, All Loving
- Mercy
- Child Abuse/Neglect

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Suffering
- Judgmental

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Fear Is a Liar — Zach Williams
Examine fear-driven accusations rather than treating them as reliable truth.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Because church people hurt me, God must be just like them"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Because church people hurt me, God must be just like them." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What was done in God's name?
- ☐ How is God different from them?
- ☐ How does Jesus treat the hurt?
- ☐ Who can I get support from?
- ☐ What do I need from God?
- ☐ What can I read about Jesus?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God is compassionate and gracious.
- ☐ He is near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ He does not break a bruised reed.
- ☐ Those who hurt me did not speak for Him.
- ☐ Jesus sympathizes with my weakness.
- ☐ I can come to God at my own pace.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 103:8
  "The LORD is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ Isaiah 42:3
  "A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish; He will faithfully bring forth justice."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] The real God: Each week, write one trait of God from Scripture that differs from how I was treated.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 103:8 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord is compassionate and gracious, unlike those who hurt me.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "God, All Loving" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name what happened. Write the facts of what was done in God's name.
- [ ] Get support. Tell a counselor or trusted friend; seek legal and safe help if abuse occurred.
- [ ] Read a Gospel. Read Mark slowly and note how Jesus treated hurting people.
- [ ] Pray honestly. Tell God your anger and hurt.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Because church people hurt me, God must be just like them": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	The real God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Because church people hurt me, God must be just like them.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I was hurt by people who spoke in Your name. Show me who You really are. Heal my wounds and help me meet You through Jesus, gentle with the broken. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.